

Why Clearer Systems Are Not Always Truer

Legibility, Semantic Fidelity, and Reality Drift

Reality Drift Framework — Representational Systems Brief #8

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The Basic Pattern

Modern systems depend on legibility.

Reality must become measurable, comparable, categorized, and simplified before it can be coordinated at scale.

This makes reality easier to manage.

It also changes what reality becomes.

The basic sequence is:

reality → measurement → model → prediction → policy → metric

Each transformation increases usability.

Each transformation also removes information.

Legibility increases.

Semantic fidelity decreases.

What Is Legibility?

Reality is complex.

It contains uncertainty, exceptions, relationships, history, local context, and tacit knowledge.

Most of that cannot be directly measured.

To make reality manageable, systems first simplify it.

Measurements isolate particular features.

Models organize those measurements.

Predictions project them into the future.

Policies operationalize those predictions.

Metrics determine whether the policy appears successful.

The resulting system becomes increasingly coherent.

It also becomes increasingly abstract.

Why Simplification Works

None of these transformations are mistakes.

Without simplification there could be no science, engineering, medicine, organizations, or governments.

Representation is necessary.

The problem is forgetting that simplification is a trade.

Every increase in legibility comes with a reduction in completeness.

The map becomes easier to read than the territory.

What Gets Lost

At every stage, something survives.

At every stage, something disappears.

Measurements lose context.

Models lose exceptions.

Predictions lose uncertainty.

Policies lose local judgment.

Metrics lose everything they cannot count.

The final representation often feels clearer than reality itself.

That clarity is useful.

It is not evidence that the representation is more true.

Semantic Fidelity

Semantic fidelity is the degree to which a representation preserves the meaning and structure of what it represents.

A highly legible system is not necessarily a highly faithful one.

A dashboard may accurately report the metric while failing to represent the underlying condition.

A model may predict outcomes while overlooking the causal structure that produced them.

A policy may operate consistently while no longer matching lived reality.

The representation succeeds according to its own rules.

The world has quietly changed beneath it.

Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, drift begins when systems become more responsive to increasingly legible representations than to the realities those representations were created to describe.

The measurement becomes more authoritative than the observation.

The model becomes more authoritative than the phenomenon.

The prediction becomes more authoritative than the present.

The metric becomes more authoritative than the outcome.

Each layer is internally reasonable.

Together, they can produce a system that is remarkably coherent while only weakly connected to reality.

The Core Principle

Legibility is one of civilization's greatest achievements.

It allows complex societies to coordinate across distance, scale, and time.

But legibility is not reality.

And clarity is not truth.

Every representation is a simplification.

The question is not whether information has been lost.

The question is whether enough fidelity remains for the representation to stay answerable to the world it claims to describe.

Reality Drift begins when increasing legibility is mistaken for increasing truth.

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